

402MAN

Linear Models of Communication



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DLHE survey, UG UK, 2016/17
(published 2018)

Session Intent:

- Explore the different theories and principles associated with Linear Communication Models
- Identify key components of a Linear Communication Model
- Consider the Advantages and Disadvantages of different Communication Models

Relevance?

This session links to the following Learning Outcome:

LO1- Demonstrate a knowledge of the core principles, theories and differing methods of communication and collaboration within a range of organisational contexts.

Recap of previous learning:

Define Communication:

To understand how we communicate, communication theorists have developed models that illustrate how communication plays out.

As the [US communication theorist Harold D. Lasswell](#) said, the theorists' task is to answer the question "*Who says what to whom with what effect?*".



Why is communication important?

In pairs, discuss the importance of communication.

Give examples of where specific communication skills are necessary.

What are some barriers to communication?

Please explain to the class what you discussed.



Since communication is fundamental in every organisation, it is vital we must strive to understand how it works.

Understanding communication & communication models can help us:

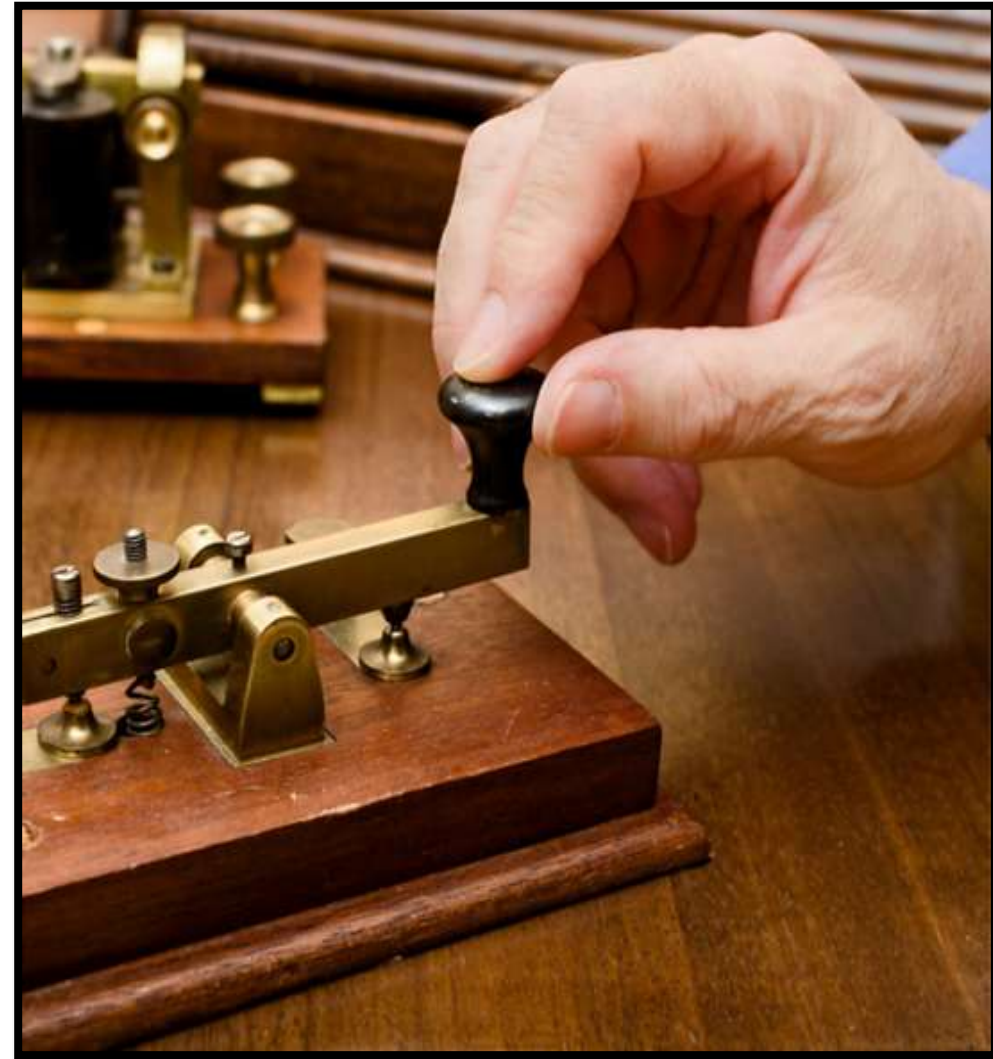
- Think about our communication situations more deliberately,
- Learn from our previous experiences, and
- Better prepare for future communication situations.

What are communication models?

- Communication can often be a complex process; it's often challenging to determine where a conversation begins and ends as well as decoding the message received.
- That is where models of communication come in — to simplify the process of understanding communication.

According to Denis McQuail (2010) *“a communication model is a selective representation in verbal or diagrammatic form of some aspect of the dynamic process of mass communication.”*

Models of communication provide us with a visual representation of the different aspects of a communication situation.



Different types of communication models.

Linear models of communication — They only look at one-way communication.

Interactive models of communication — They analyse two-way communication.

Transactional models of communication — They illustrate two-way communication where the message gets more complex as the communication event progresses.

This session focuses on Linear Models of Communication, with specific case studies and examples.

Interactive and Transactional models will be addressed in later sessions.

The Linear Communication Model

- The linear model is a straightforward representation of communication as a one-way process.
- This model consists of a sender who encodes a message, which is then transmitted through a channel to a receiver who decodes the message.

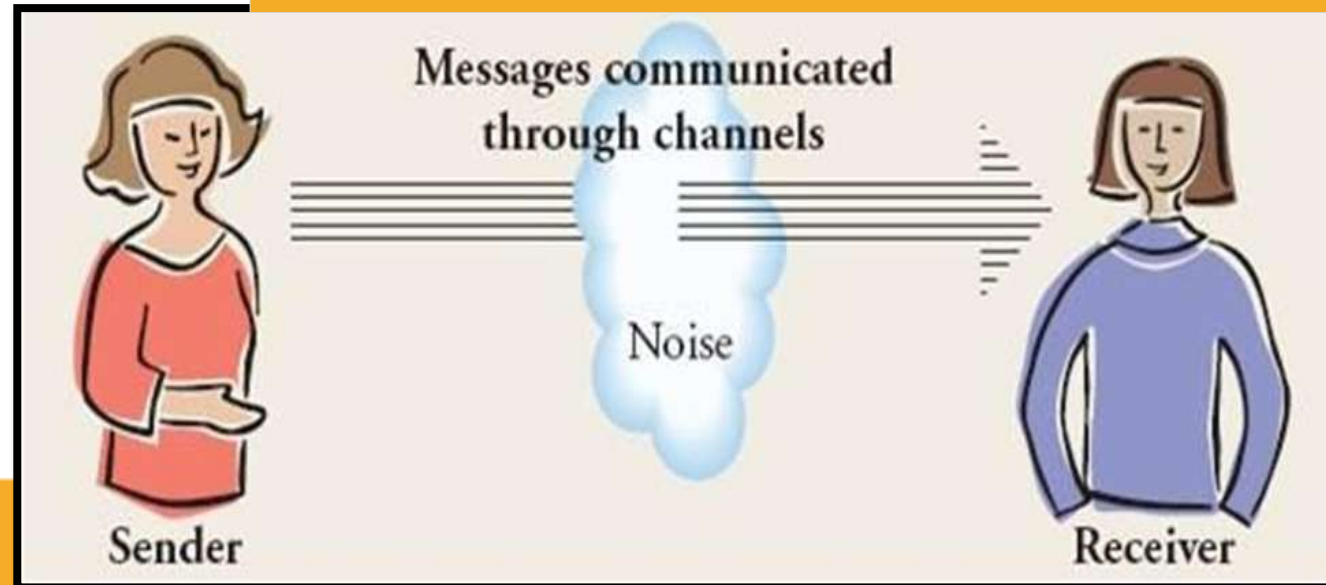
Linear communication models suggest that communication takes place only in **one direction**.

The main elements in these models are:

- The Sender
- The Receiver
- The Channel

Limitations of Linear Communication?

- Assumes that communication is a straightforward, one-way process where the sender encodes and the receiver decodes the message.
- Does not account for feedback, noise, and context that can affect the meaning and effectiveness of communication.
- Often less relevant to electronic communication and internet where the roles of sender and receiver are not clear.
- Not a dynamic way of communicating that allows for interaction and adaptation.

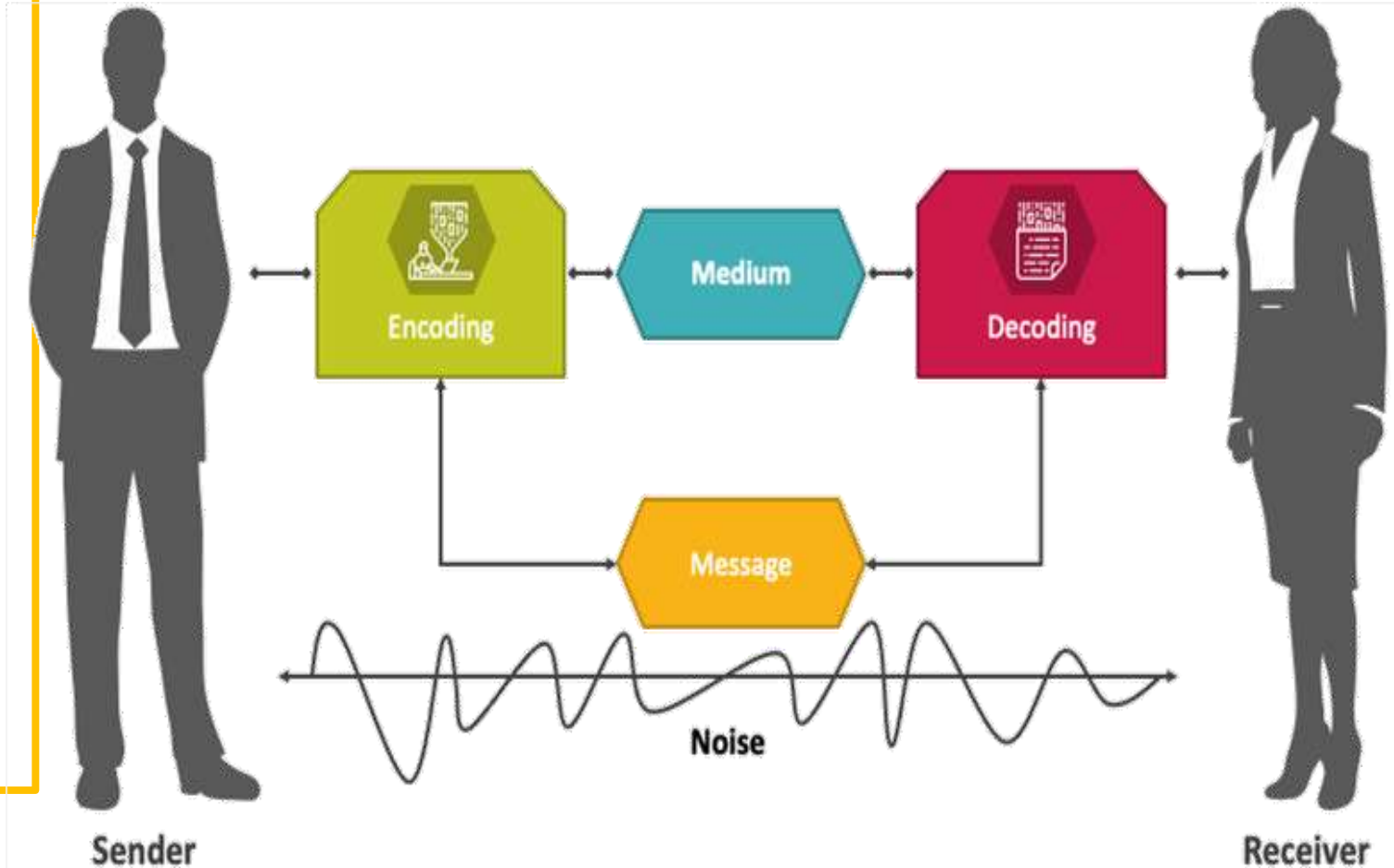


The Linear Communication Model

In this model, the sender transmits the message via a channel.

The channel, as the medium, changes the message into speech, writing, or animation.

The message reaches the receiver, who then decodes it.



Consider: Where could the Linear Communication Model be used?

1. **Mass Communication** – Television, radio broadcasts, newspapers, and online news articles.
2. **Public Speaking** – Speeches, lectures, and presentations where the audience does not interact immediately.
3. **Advertising & Marketing** – Billboards, posters, and social media ads where the message is sent without expecting a response.
4. **Educational Settings** – Recorded lessons, instructional videos, and textbooks.
5. **Corporate Communication** – Memos, emails, and reports meant to inform without direct discussion.
6. **Emergency Announcements** – Public service messages, alarms, and safety instructions.

Linear Communication in action



Linear Communication in action

One well-known business case that aligns with the Linear Communication Model is Coca-Cola's "Share a Coke" campaign.

This marketing initiative relied on **one-way communication** to deliver a message to a wide



Why It Fits the Linear Model?

- The campaign **sent a clear, one-way message** from Coca-Cola to consumers.
- There was **no expectation of direct feedback**—the company communicated a message, and consumers received it.
- While engagement happened (e.g., people sharing their Coke bottles on social media), the **core advertising message itself was linear**—it was sent out broadly without an interactive exchange.



Outcome of the Case:

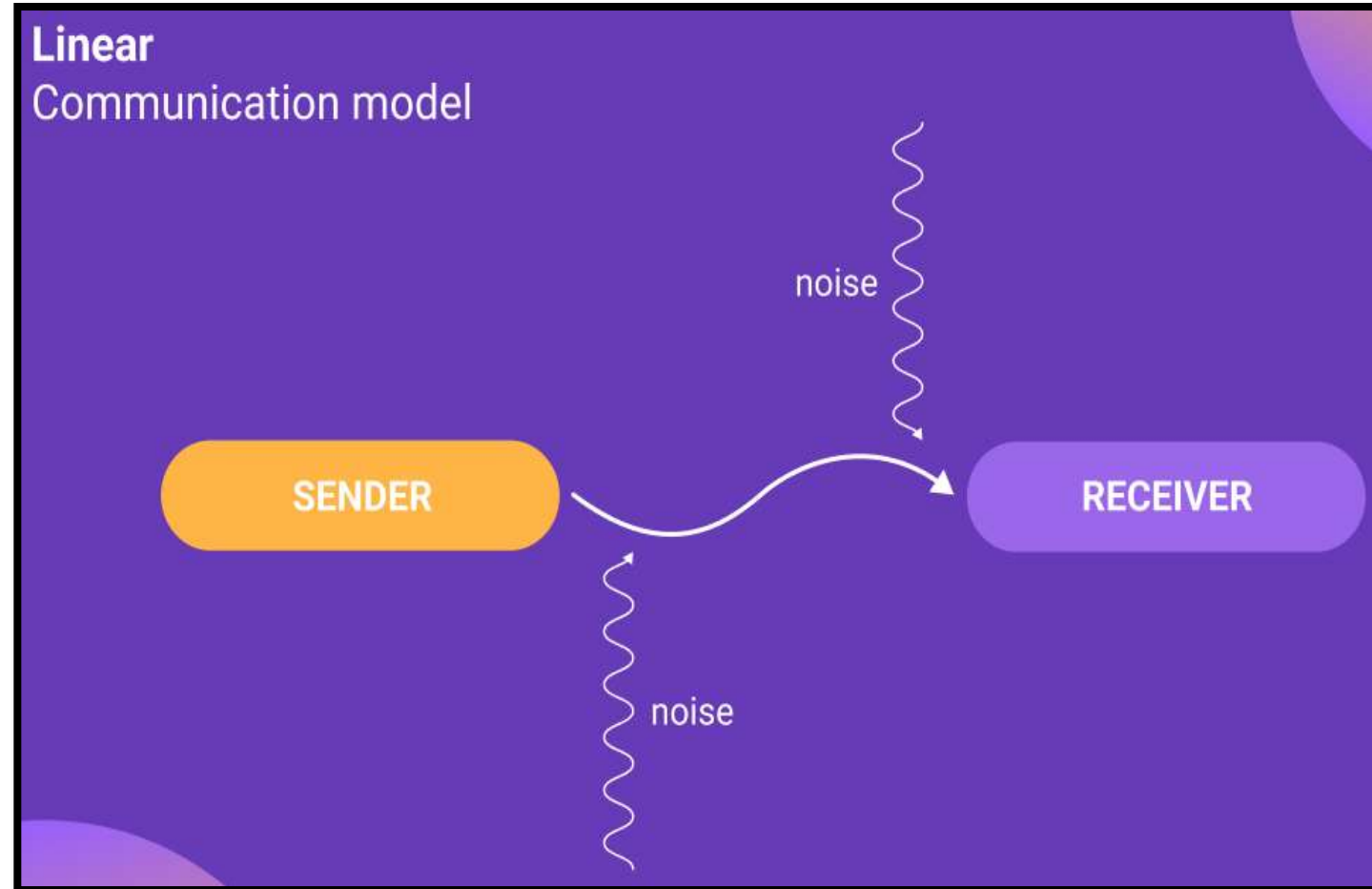
- The campaign increased sales in more than 80 countries and became one of Coca-Cola's most successful marketing strategies.
- It reinforced brand engagement while relying on a simple, one-way communication model to deliver a clear and persuasive message.



Communication VS Noise

Some linear models of communication also include noise as one of the factors that have a role in the communication process.

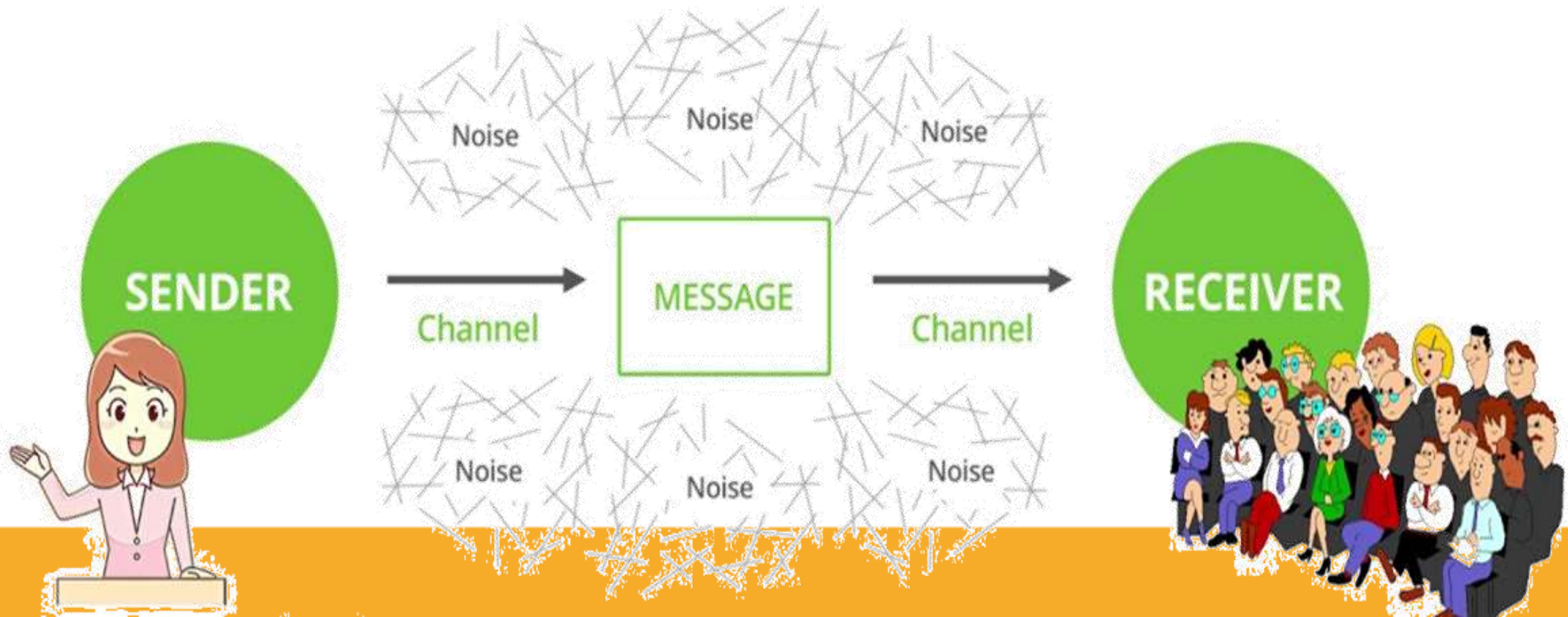
Noise acts as the added (background) element that can sometimes cause **distractions** from the original message.



Consider: What could be considered as 'noise'?

Fiske (2010) defines noise as:

“Anything that is added to the signal between its transmission and reception that is not intended by the source.”



Benefits of Linear Communication?

- Easy to understand and describes the communication process thoroughly.
- It is straightforward and targeted to specific audiences.
- Minimises miscommunication and edits, as receivers can't change the information they're receiving.
- Allows for quick transmission and message control, as senders don't have to wait for a response.
- Reduces noise interference and improves clarity, as there is only one channel and one direction of communication



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How can communication models help with communication in the workplace?

Linear Communication Models

The most prominent linear models of communication are:

1. Aristotle's communication model
2. The Shannon-Weaver communication model
3. Lasswell's communication model
4. Berlo's S-M-C-R communication model
5. Adair's Star Model

Each model comes with both advantages and disadvantages

Understanding how each model works and how they can be applied to both professional and personal life is beneficial.

Aristotle's communication model

- The oldest communication model that dates back to 300 BC, Aristotle's model was designed to examine how to become a better and more persuasive communicator.
- Aristotle's model of communication primarily focuses on **the sender** (public speaker, professor) who passes on their message to **the receiver** (the audience).
- The **sender is the only active** member in this model, whereas the **audience is passive**.
- This makes Aristotle's communication model a foolproof way to excel in public speaking, seminars, and lectures, and sits perfectly in a Linear Communication Model approach.



Aristotle's communication model

#1 The Speaker

The speaker is the person who is delivering the message. In this model, the speaker is responsible for creating and delivering the message effectively. This includes not only the words used but also the delivery style, tone, and body language.

#2 The Audience

The audience is the group of people who receive the message. In this model, the audience is considered an essential part of the communication process. The speaker needs to understand the audience's needs, interests, beliefs, and values to effectively communicate the message.

#3 The Message

The message is the content of what is being communicated. In this model, the message should be clear, concise, and persuasive. The message should be crafted with the audience in mind to ensure that it is relevant and engaging.

Aristotle's model of communication is important because it seems plausible and valid even in our modern lives.

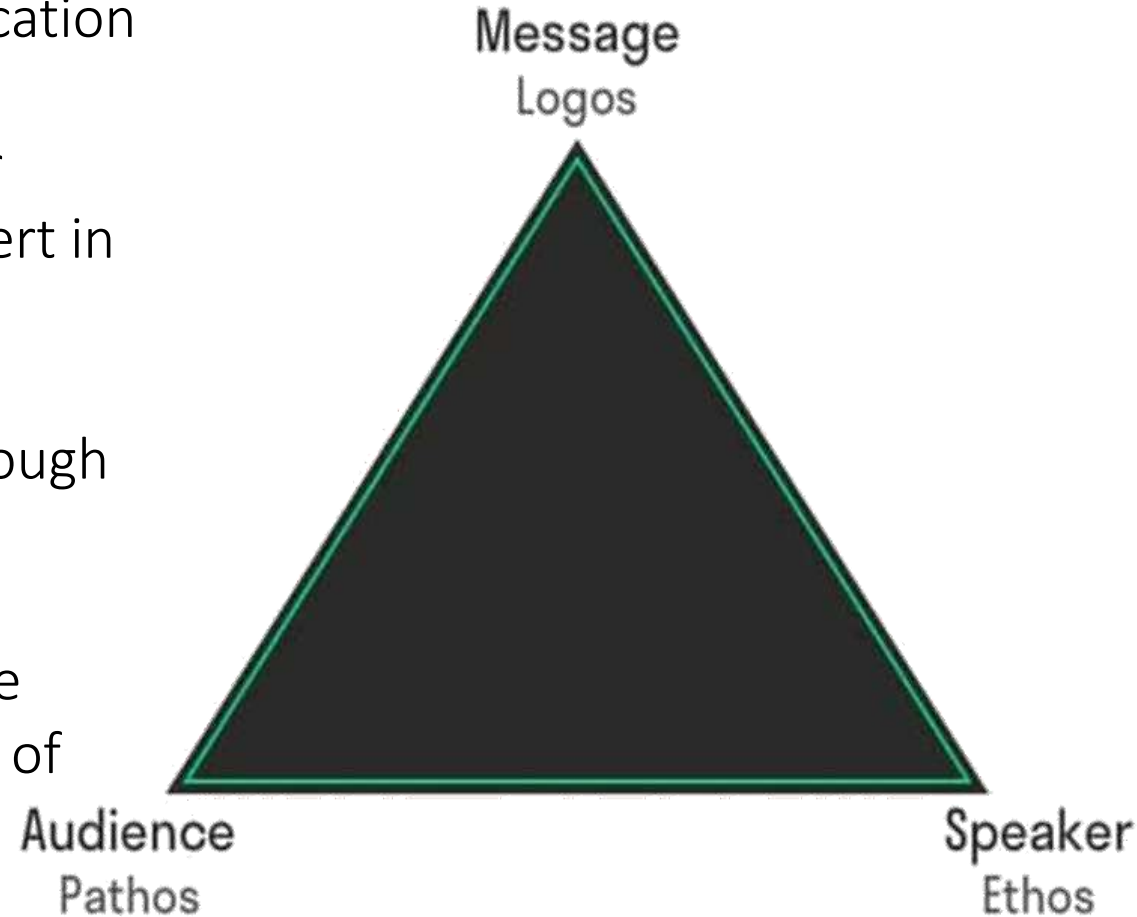
Main elements of Aristotle's communication model

Aristotle identified 3 elements that improve communication within this model:

Ethos — Defines the credibility of the speaker. Speaker gains credibility, authority, and power by being an expert in a field of their choice.

Pathos — Connects the speaker with the audience through different emotions (anger, sadness, happiness.)

Logos — Signifies logic. Namely, it is not enough for the speech to be interesting — it needs to follow the rules of logic.



Investigate why each element is required to improve communication.

Ethos

Ethos is essentially the speaker's **credibility** to talk about the subject that he or she is talking about and discusses it openly, with certainty.

What Aristotle means by ethos is the **process of the speaker establishing their credibility** or knowledge about the subject.

That can simply be done by mentioning the area of expertise he had majored in, but it can also be done by demonstrating his ability to **back up his arguments**.

Credibility can also be built by using **evidence, citing sources, or drawing on the speaker's own experience or expertise**. That's why having empirical data to back up your arguments with clear proof is essential for this point.

What this does to an audience is create an image of the speaker as someone who knows what they are talking about and as someone that they can easily rely on and trust.



Consider Ethos when writing your assignments!

Pathos

Pathos is essentially the speaker establishing an **emotional connection with the audience**.

- The idea behind Pathos is that the audience must feel that they are being communicated with and interconnected with the presenter. Emotional bonds will make the listeners fascinated, and they feel the speaker is “one of them.”
- This focuses on engaging the audience’s emotions and creating a connection with them in order to persuade or influence their attitudes, beliefs, or behaviours.
- Pathos can be conveyed through various elements of communication, such as tone of voice, facial expressions, body language, and the use of vivid language and imagery. In order to effectively use pathos in communication, Aristotle suggested that speakers should have a deep understanding of their audience and their emotional state.
- By appealing to their emotions and creating a connection with them, speakers can make their message more memorable and impactful.



Logos

- Logos refers to the **logical or rational** appeal of a message. This element focuses on the substance of the message and how it is presented to the audience.
- Logos can be seen as the **argument or reasoning behind** a message, and it is often used to appeal to the audience's sense of logic or reason. While ethos refers to the credibility or trustworthiness of the speaker or source of the message, and pathos refers to the emotional appeal in a message, logos focuses on the logical appeal and the argumentative structure of the message itself.
- To effectively use logos in communication, Aristotle suggested that speakers should use clear and **logical arguments, present evidence or facts to support their claims, and use reasoning to connect their ideas and persuade their audience.**
- By appealing to the audience's sense of logic and reason, speakers can create a persuasive message that is grounded in substance and can effectively influence their audience.



Apply Aristotle's communication model with your partner on a subject of your choosing.

Remember to structure your discussion using the following:

Ethos — Defines the credibility of the speaker. Speaker gains credibility, authority, and power by being an expert in a field of their choice.

Pathos — Connects the speaker with the audience through different emotions (anger, sadness, happiness.)

Logos — Signifies logic. Namely, it is not enough for the speech to be interesting — it needs to follow the rules of logic.

Example: Apple's iPhone Launch Events (Using Aristotle's Communication Model)



- Apple is a great example of a company that uses **Aristotle's Communication Model** to persuade and influence its customers.
- Components of Aristotle's Model in Apple's iPhone Product Launch

Launch Speaker (Sender) → Apple's CEO and product designers

Message → Introduction of the latest iPhone with new features

Audience (Receiver) → Apple customers, tech enthusiasts, media, and investors

Apple carefully **crafts its message** to build excitement and convince customers to buy the latest iPhone.

How is Aristotle's Ethos, Pathos & Logos model applied?

✓ **Ethos (Credibility)** – Establishing trust and authority Apple positions itself as a market leader in innovation. The CEO and senior designers showcase their expertise and knowledge. Apple highlights its track record of quality products.



✓ **Pathos (Emotion)** – Creating excitement and emotional connection. Apple tells stories about how the new iPhone improves users' lives. They use cinematic videos, music, and visuals to evoke excitement.



✓ **Logos (Logic & Reasoning)** – Providing facts and technical superiority. Apple demonstrates product improvements with data and comparisons. They showcase technical specs, such as battery life, processing power, and camera advancements.

Aristotle suggested that we look at 5 components of a communication situation to analyse the best way to communicate:

Speaker

Speech

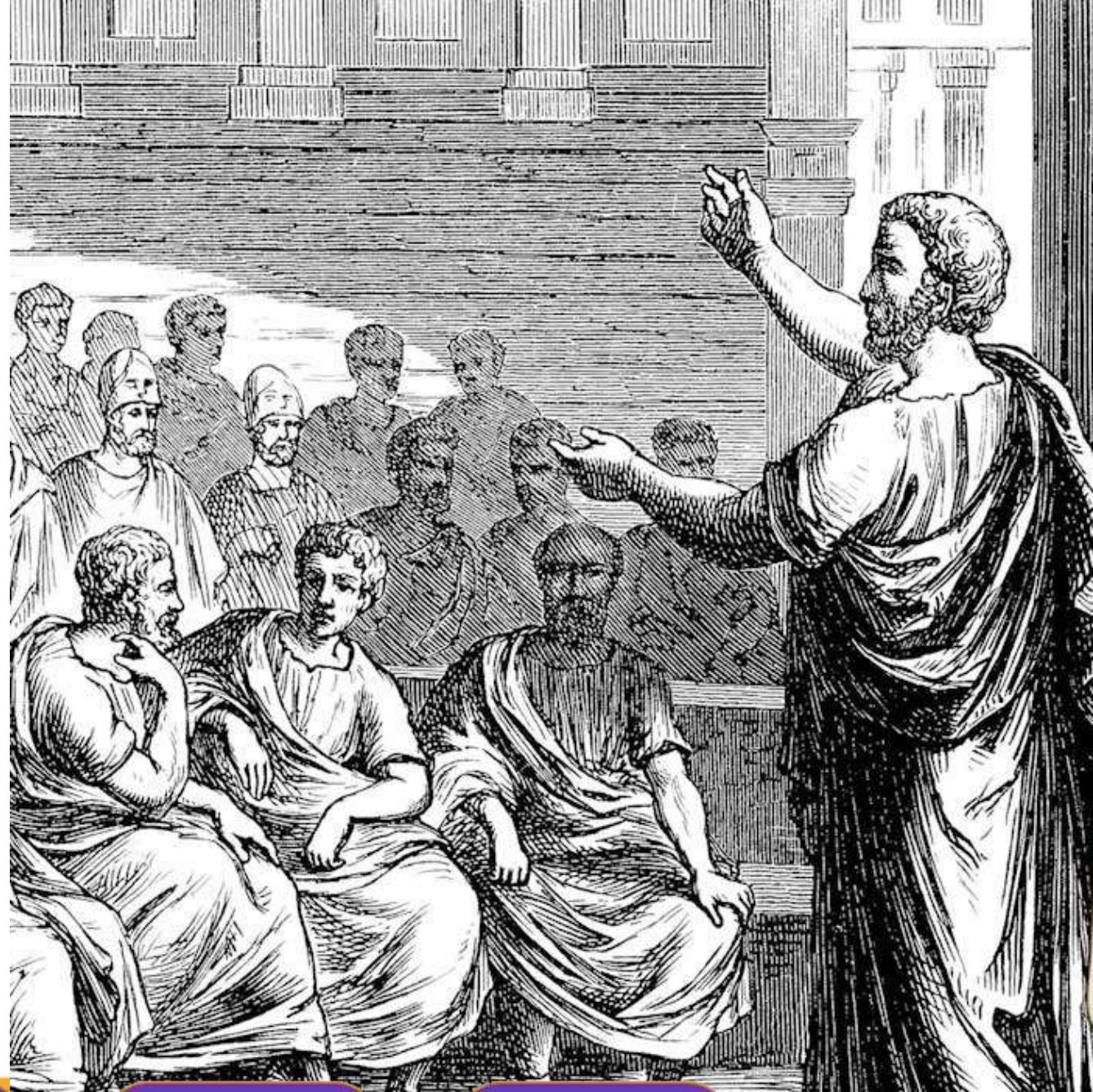
Occasion

Target audience

Effect

Aristotle advises speakers to build speech for different audience on different time (occasion) and for different effects.

The speaker must prepare his speech and analysis audience needs before he enters into the stage. His words should influence in audience mind and persuade their thoughts towards him.



SPEAKER



SPEECH



OCCASION



AUDIENCE



EFFECT

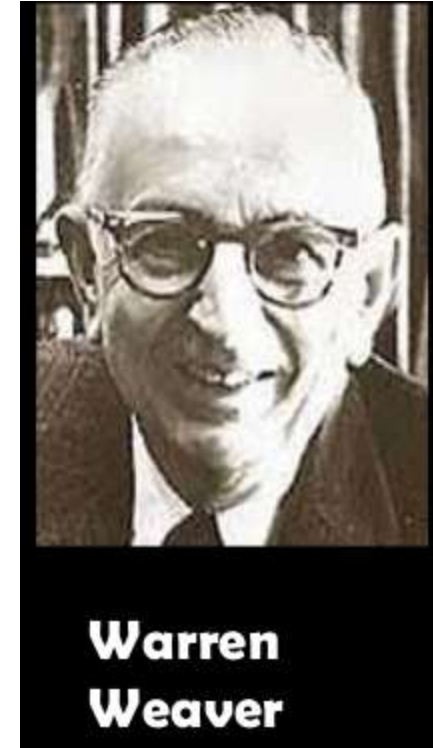
The Shannon-Weaver Model (1949)

The Shannon-Weaver Communication Model is considered one of the most popular methods of communication.

Both Shannon and Weaver were mathematicians, who developed their work during the Second World War in the Bell Telephone Laboratories.

They aimed to discover which channels are most effective for communicating.

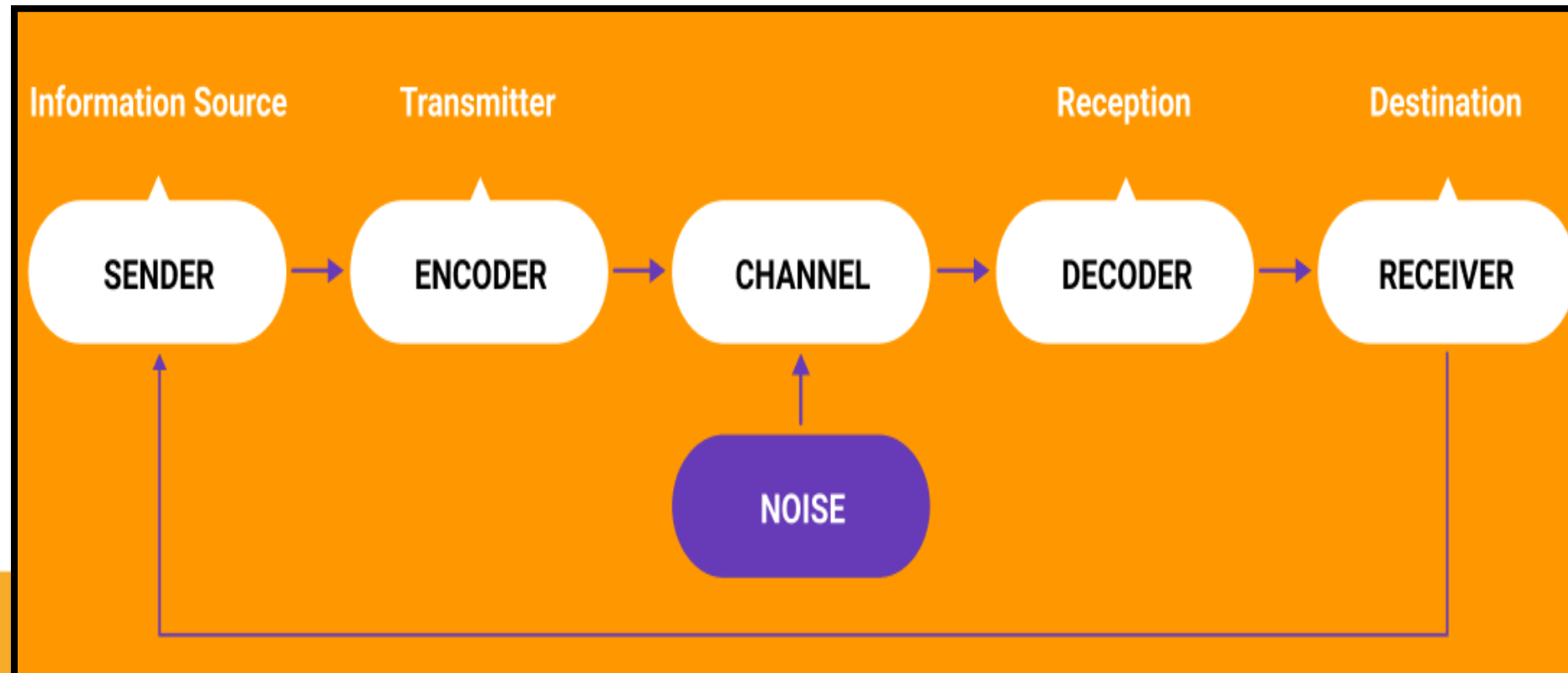
Although they were doing research as part of their engineering endeavours, they claimed that their theory is applicable to human communication as well.



What is the Shannon-Weaver model of communication?

The Shannon-Weaver communication model, is a mathematical communication concept that proposes that communication is a linear, one-way process that can be broken down into 5 key concepts.

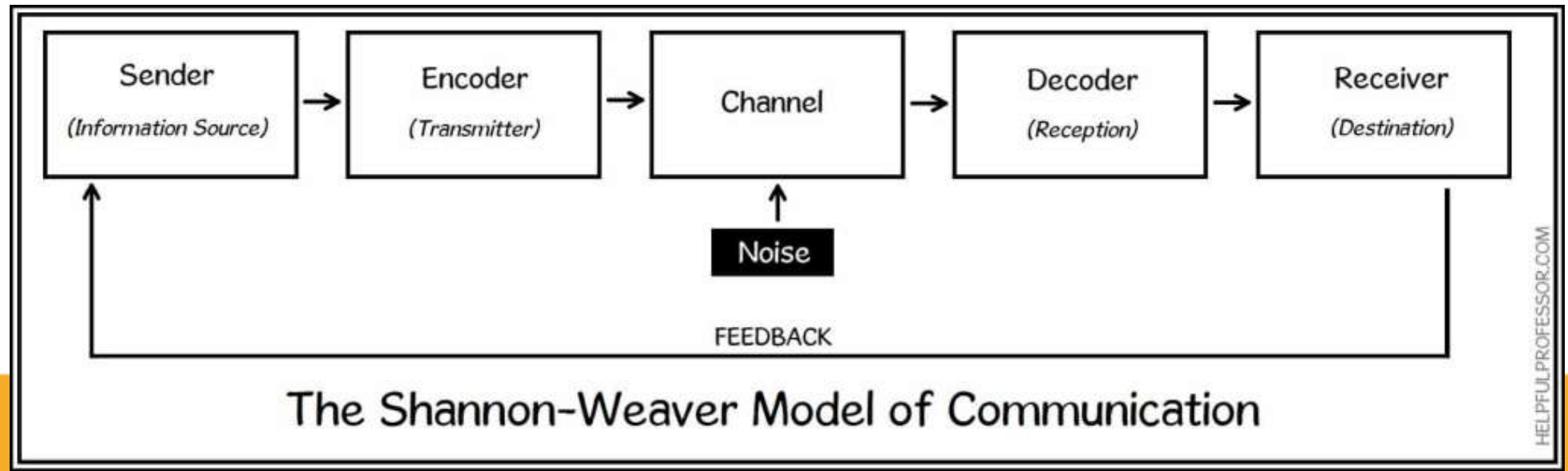
- Sender,
- Encoder,
- Channel,
- Decoder, and
- Receiver.



Shannon-Weaver model of communication

The Shannon-Weaver model was originally designed for **technical communication** (e.g., telephones and radios) but has since been applied to various fields, including **business, education, and media**.

Shannon (1948 p. 379) explains, *“The fundamental problem of communication is that of reproducing a message sent from one point, either exactly or approximately, to another point”*



Components of the Shannon-Weaver Model:

#1 Sender:

The information source starts the process by choosing a message to send, someone to send the message to, and a channel through which to send the message.

#2 Encoder:

The encoder is the machine (or person) that converts the idea into signals that can be sent from the sender to the receiver.

#3 Channel:

The channel of communication is the infrastructure that gets information from the sender and transmitter through to the decoder and receiver.

#4 Noise:

Noise interrupts a message while it's on the way from the sender to the receiver. It's named after the idea that 'noise' could interrupt our understanding of a message.

#5 Decoder:

Decodes a message from binary digits or waves back into a format that can be understood by the receiver

#6 Receiver:

This is the step where the person finally gets the message, or what's left of it after accounting for noise.

Step 7- Feedback

The 'feedback' step was not proposed by Shannon and Weaver in the original 1948 model.

Norbert Weiner added the feedback step in response to criticism of the linear nature of the approach. ('Linear' means that the messages are only going one way).

Feedback occurs when the receiver of the message responds to the sender in order to close the communication loop. They might respond to let the sender know they got the message or to show the sender:

- Whether they got the message clearly without noise
- How well they understood the message

Align the explanations to the correct concept:

Sender
Encoder
Channel
Decoder
Receiver

Any interference that affects the message's clarity (e.g., background noise, technical issues, or language barriers).

The person or system that receives and interprets the message.

Converts the transmitted signals back into a format understandable by the receiver (e.g., a speaker converting electrical signals into sound).

The medium through which the message travels (e.g., phone call, email, television, radio).

Converts the message into signals that can be transmitted (e.g., a microphone converting voice into sound waves).

The person or system that generates the message (e.g., a speaker, writer, or broadcaster)

Task:

Using Shannon-Weaver Communication Model, consider how this applies to Coca-Cola's "Share a Coke" campaign".

Share
a Coke[®]
with...



Coca-Cola's "Share a Coke" Campaign (Using the Linear Communication Model)

#1 Sender (Information Source):Coca-Cola as the brand developed the campaign idea.

#2 Encoder (Transmitter):The marketing team designed advertisements, social media posts, and product packaging with personalised names.

#3 Channel (Medium):TV commercials, social media ads, billboards, in-store displays, and printed Coke bottles.

#4 Noise (Potential Distortion):Misinterpretation of the campaign in different cultures. Limited availability of certain names, leading to customer frustration. Competition from rival brands that countered with their own marketing campaigns.

#5 Decoder (Receiver's System):Consumers viewed the ads or purchased a Coke with their name on it.

#6 Receiver (Audience):The general public, especially younger consumers, who engaged with the campaign by buying and sharing personalized bottles.



What are some Strengths of this Model?

- ✓ **Clear structure** – It systematically explains the communication process.
- ✓ **Applies to different fields** – Works in media, technology, education, and business.
- ✓ **Highlights the impact of noise** – Helps in understanding communication barriers.



What are the Limitations of this Model?

- ✗ **Lacks feedback** – It assumes one-way communication, not interaction.
- ✗ **Ignores context** – Doesn't consider emotions, relationships, or social factors.
- ✗ **Assumes a perfect transmission** – It doesn't fully account for misunderstandings.



Session Recap:

Have we:

- Explored different theories and principles associated with Linear Communication Models
- Identified key components of a Linear Communication Model
- Considered the Advantages and Disadvantages of different Communication Models



Thank you.

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